

The Role of the Shliach in Grief and Mourning

DEAR FELLOW SHLIACH,

I work as the youth director in our community Chabad House. A number of months ago, one of our baalei batim lost his mother, lo aleinu. As circumstance had it, he was more familiar with me than with the head shliach, and he asked me to conduct the funeral, even though this is not my area of expertise. Though I have filled this role a few times and feel somewhat familiar with “protocol,” I always wish I could be more empathetic and find the right thing to say at the right time to make the experience meaningful. I feel this is an area most shluchim could probably benefit from. Any ideas would be appreciated.

Response from
Rabbi Ben-Zion Chanowitz
Shliach to Monticello, New York

The passing of a relative is quite a significant occurrence, with the potential for lifelong ramifications.

Regardless of the shliach’s role within his community, if he is able to empathize, comfort, and guide a person through his tragedy, he will have connected with the person in a deep, core manner than cannot be done under normal circumstances.

The most important thing to do when someone is facing the imminent or recent passing of a relative is simply be there. At such a crucial juncture, people are looking for

understanding and guidance. If you want to be the address they will turn to, you must put yourself in the center and not stand on the sidelines.

Empathize

When I am notified that someone has passed on, the first thing I do is call the family. I tell them, “I have just heard that so and so has passed away. I am so sorry.” The simple statement “I am sorry” is quite powerful and carries over your sincere feelings without the need to say anything else. Later in the conversation, I ask the family member when would be an appropriate time to meet for an hour and prepare for the funeral.

It is important not to attempt to comfort someone in the throes of

grief. It is highly inappropriate to come up with any sort of explanation as to why this has happened. If a shliach puts himself into the minds and hearts of the ones experiencing the tragedy and tries to relate to where they are standing, he will easily be able to empathize.

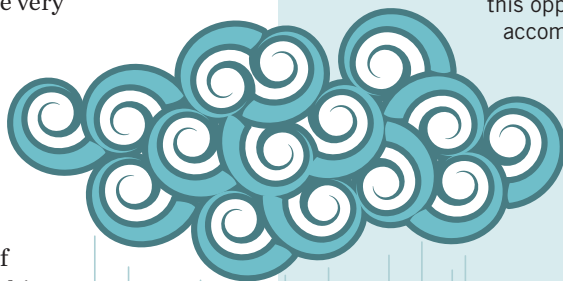
“A gutte kasheh is besser vee a schlechter teretz.” We have the same questions that they do, and we don’t have any answers. We don’t know Hashem’s plan. We feel bad, and we ask that Hashem give us wisdom and insight. This is what we would do for ourselves, and this is what we should do for them. Answer the person’s questions with, “You’re really right.” “I feel so bad.” “Your question is a very strong one.” “It is so difficult to

understand what has happened.” “So and so was a really good person.” While obviously staying within halachic boundaries, these kinds of comments let the family members know that you are relating to their pain. While feeling so vulnerable, it is important for the family to know that there is someone compassionate who understands and will help them through their sorrow.

As a general rule, when people are suffering and you don’t know what to tell them, saying “may Hashem give you strength” can be very meaningful. It tells them, I am acknowledging that this is a very difficult time for you and wish you the ultimate measure of assistance through this ordeal.

Shedding Light On Significance

The passing of a relative brings family together and gets them thinking about their lives, their ancestors, and what they stand for. They want to hear about the everlasting positive impact that this person has made. Additionally, such a time finds the family with a heightened sensitivity to spiritual perspectives and often a desire to increase in Jewish observance, such as saying kaddish, giving tzedoko, or doing other mitzvos that they might not usually be interested in otherwise. It is critical to bring those aspects to light at this time if you see their receptivity.



Rituals Made Meaningful

SUCCESSFUL SUGGESTIONS

As a general rule, I do not read from my notes while delivering speeches. The only exception is my speeches at funerals. (Of course, I make eye contact while doing so.) At this sensitive time, I want to be accurate.

The sweetest word a person can hear is his own name. I make a point of including the names of each and every one of the children and grandchildren, each with equal measure, regardless of whether I am more acquainted with one than another or whether one was not as involved with the family as the others. I stay away from family politics.

Concluding my speech, I ask forgiveness from the deceased in the name of the community, family, and friends, in case he may have been wronged in any way. I also always mention Moshiach. It is important not to miss this opportunity. As a final note, I explain that "levaya" means accompaniment. We are accompanying the deceased on his last journey, following from behind. I then invite the crowd to follow the procession.

After setting the solemn tone through my own speech, I invite the family members to speak. Their approach may be different than mine; they may occasionally express humor, but that's okay—humor is another expression of grief.

Translations and Medroshim

At the funeral, I always read and translate pesukim of Tehilim or the quotation from Koheles of “Lakol zman vo’eis,” in addition to Tzidduk Hadin and Keil Molei Rachamim. Though there are English translations available of the above selections, I have found it difficult to find translations that are meaningful. I recommend that a shliach translate the text himself, not necessarily verbatim. By picturing his listeners, he will be able to tailor the translation in a manner that will make it most relatable to them and help them understand its message.

Sometimes, I tell the story from the medrash on Koheles of two ships at a port: One ship is leaving, and the other has just arrived. Nobody pays attention to the ship that is leaving because they do not know what the nature of its journey will turn out to be. Instead, everyone at the port is fixated on the ship that has just arrived, celebrating its vast accomplishments. So too, when a person is born, we do not know the nature of his deeds, but after he has lived a full life, we *do* know the nature of his deeds and can celebrate them.... I then turn to the coffin and begin speaking.

Kriah

Though very much accepted in the frum community, in non-frum circles fulfilling the mitzva d’oraissah of kriah on a garment has been replaced with the tearing of a ribbon; people are quite reluctant to tear their own clothing. I have found that explaining the significance of this mitzva from an emotional perspective has generated agreement to fulfill it properly more than ninety percent of the time.

When the mourners are in a serious state of mind, I explain: The act of kriah expresses that someone

has been torn away from our hearts. This will leave a permanent tear that can never be repaired, neither halachically nor emotionally.

While in some traditions people try to distract themselves after the passing of a close relative, Jewish tradition confronts the loss. We focus on it, taking a week off of work and staying home. We think about the good times, our relationship with the deceased, and the lessons we have learned from the deceased's conduct during his life. We deal with the loss immediately instead of needing to deal with it later. Tearing kriah at the onset of the mourning period helps us to accomplish that goal. Additionally, while many would prefer to cover up their grief while in public, wearing the tear publicly reminds us that we are not meant to keep our grief private.

Kaddish

There is nothing more meaningful to the neshomo of the parent than the child's kaddish. It is best to encourage mourners to come to shul and say kaddish, whether once a week or multiple times per week. Additionally, the shliach can refer the mourners to subscribe to the kaddish service available through the Lubavitch Youth Organization.

It is important to be sensitive to the female mourners. When the males are given the opportunity to recite kaddish, the women can be encouraged to light Shabbos candles. While her eyes are covered, a woman davens for her family. During the year following the passing of a close relative, it is traditional for her to recite a prayer for the deceased, as well.

Shiva

It is important to meet with the family of the deceased at the shiva home shortly following the funeral. This is a good time to get to know the relatives. At the shiva, I usually tell over the sicha on Parshas Chayei Sara¹ regarding why the name of the parsha is "Chayei Sara" if it speaks of her passing. I also frequently relate a story from the Gemoro regarding passing and funerals.²

I explain the significance of lighting a yahrtzeit candle: A candle illuminates a dark room, providing direction to a person who would otherwise not have known where to go. It also provides warmth to those who stand nearby. In Mishlei,³ Shlomo HaMelech writes, "Ner Hashem nishmos odom." When a person is alive, he is physically with us. Like a candle, he provides direction, helping us distinguish between right and wrong. The warmth he generates is the good, close feeling we have when we are near him. When the person passes on, although he is not physically with us, he is still producing spiritual light and spiritual warmth because his guidance is still with us as long as we follow his ways. The lessons he has taught and the guidance he has given can serve as a light to direct us in our own life's journey. The more we take him with us, the more he will be present.

Following this thought, I speak of the importance of continuing to do the things that were important to the deceased. By undertaking and completing a project in an area in which he aspired, and doing so in his name, his guidance continues on.

Related Reading

Recommended by Rabbi Ben-Zion Chanowitz



The Jewish Mourner's Companion

By Rabbi Zalman Goldstein

Guides mourners and rabbis through the funeral and mourning process, including all relevant prayers, as well as explanations of the various customs and rituals. Maariv also included.



The RCA Lifecycle Madrikh

By Rabbi Reuven P. Bulka

Contains halochos, minhogim, and maamarei Chazal of all lifecycle events, as well as Jewish perspectives from traditional sources. All content in this volume appears in both Hebrew and English.

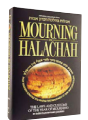
Rabbi Chanowitz notes that the version published by ArtScroll is somewhat abridged.



The Funeral and Cemetery Handbook

By Rabbi David Weinberger and Rabbi Jacob J. Schacter

Serves as a guide to the procedures and protocol of funerals and cemeteries.



Mourning in Halacha

By Rabbi Chaim Binyamin Goldberg

A comprehensive book that discusses the laws and customs of the year of mourning.



The Jewish Way in Death and Mourning

By Maurice Lamm

Can help shlichim relate to those in mourning as well as serve as a clear and comforting handbook to the mourners on the Jewish perspective of the subject.



Darkei Chessed

By Rabbi Yitzchok Dovber Ushpol

Includes hilchos aveilus and minhogei Chabad.



Nachamu Ami

By Rabbi Moshe Tzvi No'eh

A concise compendium of hilchos aveilus al pi minhogei Chabad.



Pnei Boruch—Melaket Aveilus B'Halocho

By Rabbi Chaim Binyamin Goldberg

A melaket on aveilus v'halocho that is well rounded and includes many opinions.



Kol Bo al Aveilus

By Rabbi Yekusiel Yehuda Greenwald

A melaket of hilchos aveilus and minhogim.



Nitei Gavriel

By Rabbi Gavriel Zinner

A melaket of hilchos aveilus, including Chassidishe minhogim.

But, while many people become inspired to take on new mitzvos in memory of the deceased, it is important to sense whether this is the case or not. Especially in such a sensitive time, pushing observance on someone who is not looking for it can have extremely negative effects on the grieving experience and the person's Yiddishkeit in general thereafter.

When meeting with the family members before the funeral, I go through the family history with them so that I will be describing Bubby through the perspective of her children. What were the important milestones in her life? Whom did she marry? How was it for her children while they were growing up? What did a typical evening look like? What were her values? What did you learn from her? How would she want to be remembered? At the end of the hour, I have a rich family history.

At the funeral, I usually choose not to speak about the weekly parsha; I speak about the person. I present the details of the person's life and highlight what they'd want to be remembered. Every person has Torah values that he stood for, be it education, honesty, living together in peace, etc. Instead of giving over a traditional dvar Torah on the matter, I let it speak through the life of the deceased. My message to the children and grandchildren is that these values are what the parent would like to see carried through in the following generations. Although I simply relate what the family of the deceased has told me, they consistently come to thank me and tell me how amazingly I have spoken.

Experiencing the passing of a loved one is difficult, but when a person feels that their rabbi simply and truly

cares and shares the pain, this will have made all the difference. By adding insight, inspiration, and a call to action, a shliach can turn someone's pain into a most powerful impetus toward a higher calling. 🇮🇱

Written by Mrs. Elky Raitport

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